Aquifer Open Study Notes

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2 Corinthians

2 Corinthians 1:1–2

- In the first century, letters usually started with the writer's name and the recipient's name, followed by a greeting (see Acts 15:23; 23:25–26). Paul follows this pattern.
- Paul emphasizes his role as an apostle. His position as God's chosen representative to establish the church had been questioned in Corinth.

2 Corinthians 1:2

Paul changes the usual, plain "greetings" (Greek chairein) into a meaningful message by praying for God's grace (Greek charis) and peace for his readers.

2 Corinthians 1:3

Father of compassion: God enjoys showing kindness to his people and listening to his children's cries (Psalm 145:18–19).

2 Corinthians 1:3–11

Paul now expresses joyful thanks. He is happy that, despite many troubles, God has given him special comfort (1:4–7) and saved him from death in Asia (1:8–11).

2 Corinthians 1:4–6

Suffering helps Christ's servants understand and empathize with others. Paul is not a distant pastor; he connects with the people he serves.

2 Corinthians 1:6

it is for your comfort and salvation: Paul shares in their troubles and offers encouragement to promote their spiritual well-being.

2 Corinthians 1:8–11

- dear brothers: The Greek word adelphoi is a traditional term of affection for family members, both male and female.
- the hardships we encountered in the province of Asia: The trouble faced in the province of Asia is hard to pinpoint. One suggestion is the riot in Ephesus (Acts 19:23–41). Another is that Paul was tried in a civil court and faced possible execution in Ephesus (2 Corinthians 1:9; see 1 Corinthians 15:32). It is less likely that he suffered a severe life-threatening illness. Paul often faced mortal danger (2 Corinthians 1:10; see also 4:10–12; 6:9; 11:23), but he was wonderfully rescued by divine help (1:11).

2 Corinthians 1:12

holiness: Some manuscripts use the word honesty. In Greek, the two words are very close in spelling. Hagiotēti means "holiness." Haplotēti means "honesty."

2 Corinthians 1:12–14

People criticized Paul's travel plans and his broken promise to visit Corinth. They accused him of being unreliable, like those who say "Yes" but mean "No" (1:17). Before addressing this accusation, he explains his motives in his ministry and letters.

2 Corinthians 1:15–2.2

Paul had changed his travel plan. In 1 Corinthians 16:5, he hoped to visit Corinth after going through Macedonia. He had promised to visit Corinth earlier (perhaps in his "severe letter," 2 Corinthians 7:8) on his way north. Now, he had to return to the original plan, and the earlier visit, which would have brought a double blessing, would not happen after all.

2 Corinthians 1:17

People criticized Paul for not making decisions and breaking his promise. Paul protested with anger.

2 Corinthians 1:18–20

But as surely as God is faithful: God is faithful, so we can trust him, His promises in Christ, and his work through the apostles.

2 Corinthians 1:18–22

Paul's enemies in Corinth had already attacked his character, calling him unreliable and deceitful (1:17). They then accused his entire message of being uncertain. In these verses, Paul responds to that accusation.

2 Corinthians 1:19

Silas was a famous Christian leader from the church in Antioch (see Acts 15:22, 27, 32; 1 Thessalonians 1:1; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1 Peter 5:12).

2 Corinthians 1:20

God has confirmed the Old Testament prophecies by fulfilling them through Christ. This the "Yes." Believers respond with "Amen," which means "confirmed and agreed."

2 Corinthians 1:21–22

- God enabled, commissioned (literally anointed), and endorsed Paul's ministry, equipping him for his work.
- both us and you: The Holy Spirit identifies all believers as God's own (literally sealed). The Holy Spirit is God's gift to his people (see Romans 8:1–27; Galatians 3:2–7; 5:5–6, 16–26; Ephesians 1:13–14).
- a pledge of what is to come: A pledge is a commercial term for a deposit or down payment, guaranteeing full possession (see 2 Corinthians 5:5; Ephesians 1:14).

2 Corinthians 1:23–2.2

God as my witness: This mild oath shows he is telling the truth (see 1 Samuel 12:5; 20:12; Job 16:19; compare Ruth 1:17; 1 Samuel 14:44; 2 Samuel 3:35; 1 Kings 2:23; Jeremiah 42:5). Paul changed his travel plans to avoid giving them a severe rebuke (2 Corinthians 1:23) and to prevent another painful visit (2:1).

2 Corinthians 2:1

Paul's earlier visit was very painful and caused him great distress. This visit is not recorded in Acts. It likely happened during Paul's three-year ministry in Ephesus (see Acts 19:8–22). During that visit, Paul strongly criticized the church (2 Corinthians 1:23) and an unnamed man insulted him (2:5–11).

2 Corinthians 2:3–4

After his painful visit (2:1), Paul wrote a letter with great anguish and many tears. It was meant for the Corinthians' benefit. That letter (see also 7:8–10) seems to have been lost. However, it effectively brought about the needed repentance and change.

2 Corinthians 2:5–11

These verses result from Paul's earlier visit and the insult he received. After Paul's severe but tearful letter, the church condemned the man's behavior and disciplined him (2:6). The man repented, so now it was time to forgive and comfort him, as Paul had already done.

2 Corinthians 2:11

- If we practice forgiveness like Paul, Satan will not trick us into being too lenient on sin or too harsh on offenders.
- we are not unaware of his schemes: Compare 11:3, 14; Ephesians 6:11.

2 Corinthians 2:12–13

After the riot at Ephesus (Acts 19:1–20:1), Paul traveled to the seaport of Troas (Acts 20:5). He was eager to hear from Titus about the outcome of the serious but emotional letter (2 Corinthians 2:4), so he went to Macedonia in northern Greece to meet him.

2 Corinthians 2:14

Like captives in a Roman general's victory parade, Paul was part of Christ's triumphal procession (compare 1 Corinthians 4:9; Ephesians 4:7–11), showing signs of willing service (see Romans 1:1; Galatians 6:17).

2 Corinthians 2:14–7.4

At this point, the story about finding Titus stops and will continue at 7:5. Paul shifts to talk about his work as an apostle sharing the good news about Jesus.

2 Corinthians 2:15–16

Incense was scattered along the parade route of a victorious Roman general, and people received it in two ways. For the captives heading to the arena and death, it smelled like death and doom. For the victors, it was a life-giving perfume. This is similar to those who share the good news about Jesus. It either leads to eternal life or seals the fate of those who reject it (compare 1 Corinthians 1:18).

2 Corinthians 2:17

- Paul compares his service to that of his opponents.
- They preach for personal gain and distort the truth, like merchants in Paul's time who sold poor-quality goods or innkeepers who diluted wine. In contrast, Paul preached sincerely and with Christ's authority (compare 1:12; 4:2). Paul denies having selfish motives again in 11:1–12:21.

2 Corinthians 3:1–3

Paul's ministry was proven by the lives changed by the good news about Jesus, not by a letter of recommendation (compare Acts 18:27). Christ, who caused this change, used Paul to guide believers to him. The true signs are not in letters written with pen and ink on parchment, but in the fruit of the Spirit (Galatians 5:22–23) in human lives and engraved on human hearts.

2 Corinthians 3:4–6

The old written covenant refers to the law of Moses as interpreted by Jewish rabbis. It results in death for those who see it as a path to salvation. The law is good (Romans 7:12–14), but those who try to earn merit

through it fail. Earning merit through the law leads to either wrongdoing or pride. In both cases, the law brings condemnation (2 Corinthians 3:9).

2 Corinthians 3:4–18

Paul compares his ministry to others by contrasting the old covenant of written laws (Exodus 31:18) with the new covenant written on human hearts (Jeremiah 31:33).

2 Corinthians 3:7–11

- The old covenant had moments of glory, like when the face of Moses shone from talking with the Lord (Exodus 34:29–35).
- The old way has been replaced by the new, eternal way (Hebrews 8:8–13).

2 Corinthians 3:12–15

The old covenant, symbolized by the veil worn by Moses, caused fear and did not clear spiritual blindness.

2 Corinthians 3:16–18

Believers who turn to the Lord find freedom in the Spirit. We gain something Moses never experienced as we become more like Christ (4:4; John 1:1–14; Colossians 1:15; Hebrews 1:1–4) and reflect the Lord's glory. Experiencing divine glory in this life helps us become like Christ in the next life (Romans 8:29; Galatians 4:19; Philippians 3:21; 1 John 3:2).

2 Corinthians 4:1

This new way (or this new ministry) demonstrates God's mercy. Paul felt honored to share the message of good news (1 Corinthians 15:9–11; 1 Timothy 1:12–17).

2 Corinthians 4:2

Paul's ministry was honest, unlike some other preachers (2:17).

2 Corinthians 4:3–4

The good news about Jesus divides people into two groups: those who stay in darkness and those enlightened by God (see Acts 26:18, compare John 3:19–21). God brings people to him, moving them from darkness to the light of his presence (Colossians 1:12–14; 1 Peter 2:9). The god of this world opposes the change the good news brings to people's hearts and minds.

2 Corinthians 4:5

we do not proclaim ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord: See also Romans 10:9–10; 1 Corinthians 12:3; Colossians 2:6.

2 Corinthians 4:7

The message of good news about Jesus is like a great treasure, but it is kept in fragile clay jars (our weak bodies). This understanding gives purpose to suffering (4:8–5:10).

2 Corinthians 4:11

Believers often endure the Lord's humiliation, confident they will also share in his triumphant, risen life (4:14).

2 Corinthians 4:12

Throughout his life of danger and exposure to mortal peril (see 1 Corinthians 15:30), Paul strengthened the faith of Christians in the churches he founded (compare Colossians 1:24; 2 Timothy 2:10).

2 Corinthians 4:13–14

The reason Paul stayed strong was his faith. It was the same kind of faith the psalm writer had (see Psalms 116:10). Paul's faith was centered in the Lord, who is alive.

2 Corinthians 4:16–17

we do not lose heart: This call to endurance comes with a reminder of what the future holds (5:1–10). The human body naturally ages and deteriorates, and Paul was especially worn down both physically and emotionally (4:8–12). But he experienced daily renewal. His spirit was refreshed and revitalized by God's power.

2 Corinthians 4:18

If we focus on our current problems, we may feel weak. However, when we view our lives in the context of eternity, we understand that our problems will soon disappear.

2 Corinthians 5:1–10

The idea of eternal hope is promising, with heavenly bodies replacing our dying ones. The God of resurrection will raise us and present us with all believers (4:14). Paul faced challenges in Ephesus, which inspired this statement about resurrection hope (1:8–11). His body's weakness reminded him of life after death, when our earthly body will be taken down in death and decay (see 1 Corinthians 15:42–57; Philippians 3:20–21).

2 Corinthians 5:2

longing to be clothed with our heavenly dwelling: This is not a wish for death. Paul longed for the Lord's return, when he would give new bodies to his people (1 Corinthians 15:51–58; Philippians 3:20–21; 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17).

2 Corinthians 5:7

We know about our future resurrection through faith (see Hebrews 11:1, 3, 27). However, the resurrection of Jesus and the Holy Spirit's presence serve as evidence of what is to come (1 Corinthians 15:1–9; Ephesians 1:14).

2 Corinthians 5:9–10

The goal of life is to please him (see also Romans 12:1–2; 14:18; Colossians 1:10; 1 Thessalonians 4:1). This goal will be tested when we stand before Christ for judgment. The judge is also our advocate, so we are confident of being found not guilty (Romans 8:1, 33–34). However, actions done in this earthly body will be evaluated and held accountable (Acts 17:31).

2 Corinthians 5:11

One reason for Paul's ministry is his respectful responsibility to the Lord. It is not a fearful dread, but a healthy respect (see Proverbs 1:7).

2 Corinthians 5:11–7.4

Paul explains the main theme of his message: reconciliation. This means turning enemies into friends and restoring relationships. Paul's ideas are based on what God did through Christ to reconcile sinners to Himself (5:18–21). He presents this explanation while defending his own ministry (5:11–17) and applying his message to the situation in Corinth (6:1–7:4).

2 Corinthians 5:12

Paul's opponents boasted about their impressive outward ministry, but they lacked sincerity in their hearts (compare 1 Samuel 16:7; Romans 2:28–29).

2 Corinthians 5:13

If we are out of our mind: This statement might suggest that during Paul's previous visit to Corinth (2:1–2), people accused him of being out of his mind when he shared the simple good news about Jesus (1 Corinthians 2:2).

2 Corinthians 5:14

Christ's love compels us: This could mean either believers' love for Christ or, more likely, Christ's love for us. This love motivates believers to spread the message of Christ through their service (see 1 Corinthians 9:16).

2 Corinthians 5:14–17

Paul's teaching on reconciliation comes from his beliefs that:

1. Christ died for all believers;
2. in Christ, believers also die to sin and self; and
3. now all believers should live for Christ.

This new life in Christ leads to a new way of seeing others and Christ.

2 Corinthians 5:16–17

- From a human perspective, Paul might recall his past belief as a Pharisee that the Messiah would free the Jews from political oppression.
- Although we once regarded Christ in this way, we do so no longer: Christ rose from the dead, began the new creation (5:17), and became the redeemer from sin and Lord of the universe (Romans 1:3–4; Philippians 2:6–11; Colossians 1:15–20).

2 Corinthians 5:18–21

- God gives his servants the message and ministry of reconciliation through Christ.
- God has given us the task of reconciling people. Paul speaks of his own ministry, but sharing this message is the responsibility of all believers. Christ's ambassadors call people to accept what God has done so they can be made right with God through Christ.
- Christ paid the penalty for people's sins to remove all barriers between God and humans and to make us right with God.

2 Corinthians 5:20

- The great privilege of believers is to be Christ's ambassadors (compare Ephesians 6:20).
- as though God were making His appeal through us: Paul does not claim to speak for God. Instead, God speaks through us.
- Christ's redeeming work for sinners allows them to "Be reconciled to God" (see Romans 5:1–11; Ephesians 2:11–22; Colossians 1:15–23). Christian witness centers on this appeal. Paul also urged the rebellious Corinthians to join his side (see 2 Corinthians 6:1).

2 Corinthians 5:21

Christ became the offering for our sin on the cross by taking the penalty of sin upon himself and dying a criminal's death. He did this even though he never sinned (John 8:46; 1 Peter 2:22; 1 John 3:5), so we might be made right with God. That is, we are set in a right relationship with God and accepted by him (see Galatians 3:13).

2 Corinthians 6:1–2

- To win over the discontented believers in Corinth, Paul asks them to listen to him and Timothy as God's servants and messengers.
- As God's fellow workers: Literally As we work together, which raises the question of whether Paul meant they were working as a team or working together with God.

2 Corinthians 6:2

This quote from Isaiah 49:8 emphasizes that God's offer of salvation can lead to reconciliation between Paul and the Corinthians. Their reconciliation with Paul would naturally follow their true acceptance of the good news.

2 Corinthians 6:3–10

Paul provides a clear picture of the challenges in his ministry (compare 4:7–18). He lists nine trials, many of which are recorded in Acts (for example, Acts 14:5–6, 19–20; 16:19–24; 21:30–36). Through their unwavering suffering for the good news, Paul and Timothy (2 Corinthians 1:1) proved they were true ministers of God.

2 Corinthians 6:6–7

Paul talks about how he faced suffering with courage. He says his strength came from the Holy Spirit within us.

2 Corinthians 6:8–10

People often attacked Paul's character as an apostle, even calling him and his colleagues imposters. Despite these attitudes, Paul remained honest. They likely thought Paul was insignificant and could be ignored, a reckless person taking unnecessary risks that made him seem almost dead already. Paul countered each of their claims with insights into spiritual reality.

2 Corinthians 6:11–13

- Paul's passionate plea shows his true feelings.
- Our hearts are open wide: These feelings continue in 7:2 (see study notes on 6:14–7:1; 7:2–4).

2 Corinthians 6:14

Do not be unequally yoked with unbelievers: This advice refers to the Jewish rule against certain mixtures (Leviticus 19:19; Deuteronomy 22:10). Paul likely referred to the Corinthians' involvement in idol worship (see 1 Corinthians 8–10; compare 1 Corinthians 10:14–22).

2 Corinthians 6:14–7.1

The connection between 6:13 and 7:2 has led many scholars to think that 6:14–7:1 might be an inserted fragment from another letter, possibly the one mentioned in 1 Corinthians 5:9. However, this section could also be a digression in Paul's writing, challenging the Corinthians to stop opposing him and his message. Paul wanted to restore relationships, and here he describes believers in Christ as forming a holy temple. Believers' identity as the temple of God encourages harmony among them and separation from the impurity of unbelieving attitudes and behaviors. Paul contrasts Christian and pagan morality using quotations from the Old Testament.

2 Corinthians 6:15

Belial: This Hebrew word means "worthless" or "good-for-nothing." During the time between the Old and New Testaments, people used it as a name for Satan.

2 Corinthians 6:16

Believers together form the temple of the living God. The Holy Spirit lives in them, making them holy (1 Corinthians 3:16; 1 Peter 2:1–10).

2 Corinthians 6:18

This quote is from 2 Samuel 7:14, but Paul includes daughters as well (see Isaiah 43:6).

2 Corinthians 7:1

- Paul wanted the church to be a holy group, filled with God's presence.
- perfecting holiness in the fear of God: Because we fear God, we should show respect in the presence of a holy God (see study note on 5:11).

2 Corinthians 7:2–4

- Make room for us in your hearts: Paul continues his request from 6:11–13 (see study note on 6:14–7:1). Paul cared deeply for the churches (11:28), seeking a strong fellowship bond. When misunderstood, he clarified his actions, as he does here.
- We have exploited no one: This means not taking their money.

2 Corinthians 7:4

in all our troubles: This might refer to Paul's many hardships (6:5) or his issues with the Corinthians. Either way, he felt joy because the church's response greatly encouraged him (as he explains in 7:5–16).

2 Corinthians 7:5–7

- Paul felt joy when he met Titus, whose presence was uplifting when he joined Paul in Macedonia (see study note on 2:14–7:4; Acts 20:1–2).
- Initially, Paul found no rest (this Greek word is used in 2 Corinthians 2:13, where it means "peace of mind") and faced only conflict, battles, and fear. Paul felt deeply discouraged, but God, who comforts the discouraged, encouraged him (compare Psalms 42:5–6). Titus arrived from Corinth with news that Paul's letter (see 2 Corinthians 2:3–4) had achieved its purpose (7:8–16). This news was the main reason for Paul's joy.

2 Corinthians 7:8–13

At first, Paul regretted sending his previous letter (see 2:3–4). Now he does not regret it, realizing the pain was worthwhile. The severe letter led the church in Corinth to repent. They rebuked the offending person —perhaps too strongly (see 2:6–11).

2 Corinthians 7:9–10

There are two types of sorrow:

1. Worldly sorrow, which does not include repentance, leads to spiritual death (for example, see Matthew 27:3–6; Hebrews 12:16–17).
2. Sorrow that turns us away from sin leads to salvation, as demonstrated when the church in Corinth responded positively to Paul's criticism.

2 Corinthians 7:13–16

The Corinthians welcomed and obeyed Titus, who was Paul's representative. This made Titus fond of them and pleased Paul. The crisis in Corinth ended, and Paul felt confident everything was fine.

2 Corinthians 7:14

Paul remained hopeful about the outcome of Titus's trip to Corinth, even though he was afraid.

2 Corinthians 8:1–2

The churches in Macedonia included the church in Philippi. According to Acts and Philippians, this church faced many troubles and was very poor. Despite this, they generously sent gifts to Paul and supported the collection (8:4–5; Philippians 1:5; 2:25–30; 4:15–20).

2 Corinthians 8:1–9.15

Paul now focuses on collecting funds for the Jerusalem church (8:4; 9:1). This relief fund aimed to help the poor believers in the holy city (Acts 11:27–30; Romans 15:25–27, 31; Galatians 2:10). Paul had previously given instructions about this matter (1 Corinthians 16:1–2). Now it was time to gather the funds (2 Corinthians 8:6). Paul hoped this gift from non-Jewish congregations to the Jewish church would strengthen ties between the two groups in the early Christian community.

2 Corinthians 8:6

When Titus returned to Corinth with this letter from Paul in Macedonia, he would begin collecting donations.

2 Corinthians 8:7

This verse is central to Paul's teaching on Christian giving (8:1–9:15). The Corinthians were known for their spiritual gifts (1 Corinthians 1:5–7; 14:12). Now, they should lead in the generous act of giving, which shows true spirituality (see 1 Corinthians 13:1–13). God had been generous to the Corinthians, so they should help the Jewish believers in need (2 Corinthians 9:13). This would show unity in Christ.

2 Corinthians 8:9

The Lord himself is the model for generous giving. He was rich in the Father's presence (John 17:5, 24) but became poor by living as a human and dying on the cross (see Philippians 2:6–11). Through this selfless act, he made people rich with the blessings of salvation.

2 Corinthians 8:10

A year ago, you began collecting an offering for Jerusalem, inspired by 1 Corinthians 16:1–2. Therefore, this letter is written at least one year after 1 Corinthians.

2 Corinthians 8:15

Paul quotes from Exodus 16:18 to explain that Christians have a shared duty. Wealthy believers, like the Corinthians, should assist poorer believers in Jerusalem. This way, everyone will have enough.

2 Corinthians 8:18–24

Two other Christian men would travel with Titus to Corinth to prevent any criticism about managing the

relief funds they collected (8:20–21). Titus and his companions would ensure proper handling of the money. The identities of the two companions are unknown.

2 Corinthians 8:23

the glory of Christ: Paul's last phrase is very expressive in Greek. They are examples of Christians who reflect the Lord's splendor (3:1–18).

2 Corinthians 9:1–5

Two reasons encourage the spirit of love in giving:

1. to follow the example of the Macedonians, who were generous despite their poverty (9:2); and
2. to avoid embarrassing Paul or themselves, as he had praised the Corinthians' generosity to the Macedonians (9:3–5).

To ensure the collection at Corinth is ready on time, Paul will send delegates (8:16–24) ahead to prepare the promised gift.

2 Corinthians 9:6

Paul uses farming to show how generosity pays off. A farmer who wants a big harvest must plant many seeds.

2 Corinthians 9:7

God loves a cheerful giver: The spirit of giving is what matters. Giving cheerfully is different from giving reluctantly (literally out of sorrow) or due to pressure.

2 Corinthians 9:8–9

As it is written: The quote from Psalm 112:9 assures us that God, who meets all human needs, will reward generosity.

2 Corinthians 9:10–14

God would match the Corinthians' generosity (9:10–11). Their generosity would help Jewish Christians (9:12), honor God (9:13), and show believers in Jerusalem that their non-Jewish brothers and sisters were true believers (9:13). This would lead to Jewish believers praying for and caring about the non-Jewish believers (9:14). Paul imagined a united, worldwide Christian church made up of both Jewish and non-Jewish believers, all united in Christ Jesus (Galatians 3:28; Ephesians 2:11–22). This unity would strongly show the Lord's work of bringing people together.

2 Corinthians 10:1

I, Paul, who am humble when face to face with you: See 10:10. Paul wrote bold letters from afar, but people mistook his gentleness and kindness for weakness. However, they forgot he had the authority of Christ (12:19; 13:3–5, 7, 10; 1 Corinthians 4:21).

2 Corinthians 10:1–6

Paul clearly states his intentions and sincerity by defending himself against accusations of acting from human motives.

2 Corinthians 10:1–13.13

- In this section, Paul defends his role as an apostle.
- These chapters present several issues due to a noticeable change in tone and style. Chapters 1–9 express joy from sinners reconciling with God and the Corinthians reconciling with Paul. However, from this point, Paul becomes defensive. These chapters contain harsh words, bitter accusations, passionate irony, and rebuke. The significant shift at 10:1 has led to various explanations:

1. These chapters might be a separate letter, possibly the "severe letter" sent earlier to Corinth (2:3–4; 7:8–9).
2. It could be that while most church members obeyed the call for reconciliation, a rebellious minority remained, and Paul addressed these four chapters to them.
3. More likely, a new situation arose after Titus reported restored harmony (7:5–16). In this case, some anti-Paul missionaries arrived in Corinth and started a strong campaign against the apostolic message of good news (see 11:4, 13–15). They claimed Paul was not a true apostle or even a true Christian (10:7) and that he had no right to bring the gospel message to Corinth, as it was their territory (10:15–16). They brought a foreign message (11:4) and had a domineering attitude. In short, they were doing Satan's work (11:13–15). Paul, worried about this new situation, reasserts his apostolic authority and writes in a way he dislikes (11:1, 16–17; 12:1) by boasting about his weaknesses and trials. Paul's apostolic authority is genuine and powerful, yet it is guided by the love shown by the crucified Jesus (10:1; 13:4–10).

2 Corinthians 10:3–5

A military metaphor strengthens Paul's argument that Paul's weapons have divine power over spiritual strongholds (see 4:3–4).

2 Corinthians 10:7–11

The rival teachers claimed to represent Christ in a way that excluded Paul due to his perceived weakness. Paul

explained that true authority is different from being a controlling leader. His authority aimed to strengthen God's people, not to harm them (see 13:10). However, he planned to address these rivals firmly when he visited Corinth (see 13:1).

2 Corinthians 10:10

- Paul's letters can be difficult and demanding, as other Christians also noticed (compare 2 Peter 3:16).
- his physical presence is unimpressive: Paul did not have an overpowering presence that forced people to obey (compare 2 Corinthians 1:24; 1 Corinthians 2:1–5). The earliest descriptions of Paul's appearance (Acts of Paul and Thecla, around AD 200) describe him as "a man of small height, almost bald, with crooked legs, but with a good body and eyebrows meeting. His nose was hooked, full of grace, for sometimes he appeared like a man and sometimes had the face of an angel."
- his speaking is of no account: Unlike Apollos (Acts 18:24), Paul was not a skilled speaker or captivating orator when he came to Corinth (see 2 Corinthians 11:6; 1 Corinthians 2:3–4). However, his message was filled with a power beyond human speech, as it was given in the Holy Spirit.

2 Corinthians 10:12

Paul accuses his enemies of having false values because they think too highly of themselves.

2 Corinthians 10:13–16

Paul respected the limits God set for his missionary work, which included working with the Corinthians. He defends his honesty and authority, stating that when he first came to Corinth (Acts 18:1–17), he did so because God called him. Paul was determined not to enter another's area (see Romans 15:20), and he was the first to bring the good news about Jesus to Corinth. His recent opponents visited the church much later (2 Corinthians 11:4), so their claim to Corinth as their area was unfounded.

2 Corinthians 10:17–18

Paul quotes Jeremiah 9:24 to show that the Lord guides all missionaries. Boasting does not matter much. Success only matters when the Lord praises our service.

2 Corinthians 11:1

I hope you will put up with a little of my foolishness: Paul uses an ironic tone. He again asks with irony for forbearance, you are already doing that. In translation this repetition makes the irony even sharper.

2 Corinthians 11:1–6

Paul feels he must explain his actions, even though he dislikes doing so. He claims a strong connection with the church (11:2). His enemies are trying to lead the Corinthian believers away from Christ.

2 Corinthians 11:2

The church is meant to be a pure bride for one husband, Christ. This metaphor originates from the Old Testament, where Israel is the Lord's bride (Isaiah 54:5; 62:5). Paul viewed himself as the "best man" (the bridegroom's close friend) who acted on behalf of the bridegroom (compare John 3:29).

2 Corinthians 11:3

The false teachers were leading the Corinthian believers away from pure devotion to Christ. They were doing Satan's work, like the serpent did in Eden (11:14; see Genesis 3:4, 13).

2 Corinthians 11:4

The false missionaries in Corinth preached about a different Jesus, a different kind of Spirit, and a different gospel than the one the Corinthians believed. It is hard to know exactly what these false teachers preached. Most likely, they promoted a powerful, dominant Christ and ignored the suffering of the cross. They probably saw themselves as powerful preachers, free from hardship and trial. In contrast, Paul's message focused on Christ crucified (13:4), and Paul's own sufferings showed true apostleship (12:1–12). This difference is central to Paul's defense of his apostleship in chapters 10–13.

2 Corinthians 11:5–6

These false teachers called themselves "super apostles" and looked down on Paul for not speaking eloquently (10:10).

2 Corinthians 11:7

because I preached the gospel of God to you free of charge?: Paul preached God's good news without expecting anything in return. As a church planter (1 Corinthians 9:3–14), Paul chose to earn his living by making tents (Acts 18:3; 20:34) instead of relying on support from new churches (1 Thessalonians 2:9; 2 Thessalonians 3:8–9). His critics in Corinth used this against him. In Greek culture, religious teachers could

claim financial support, so Paul's refusal led some to argue that his apostleship was not genuine.

2 Corinthians 11:8–9

Paul had been accepting contributions from Macedonia, specifically Philippi (Philippians 4:15–19). This apparent inconsistency made the Corinthians suspicious of his motives or doubtful of his love for them (2 Corinthians 11:11).

2 Corinthians 11:12

Paul refused support from the Corinthians (11:7–11) to demonstrate true Christian service. He wanted to contrast this with those who served to boast.

2 Corinthians 11:13–15

Paul strongly criticizes the false teachers in Corinth (compare Galatians 1:6–9). Although these teachers wanted to claim their work was like Paul's (2 Corinthians 11:12), they were actually false apostles and deceitful workers (compare Philippians 3:2). Just as Satan transformed himself into an angel of light to deceive Eve (as described in the Jewish apocryphal book The Life of Adam and Eve), his servants also pretend to be servants of righteousness. Satan's servants claim to be God's servants, but their actions are evil, and their punishment is certain (see 2 Corinthians 5:10).

2 Corinthians 11:16–29

Paul acts like a boastful fool (see also 12:11–13) to show his real qualifications as a suffering apostle. The intruders' arrogance forces Paul to write in a way that mirrors their behavior, using irony.

2 Corinthians 11:19

The Corinthians were proud of their ability to understand complex religious topics. They valued teachers who pretended to be knowledgeable. Paul had a different plan (1 Corinthians 2:1–16).

2 Corinthians 11:20–21

The Corinthian church welcomed the intruders, even when they took advantage of and insulted them. They viewed Paul's decision not to exploit them as a sign of weakness.

2 Corinthians 11:21–29

Instead of boasting about his strengths and successes like the false teachers, Paul boasts about his weaknesses and defeats, directing attention away from himself and toward God.

2 Corinthians 11:22

- Are they Hebrews?: Paul's opponents viewed Jewish heritage as a qualification for ministry (see Philippians 3:5).
- Are they Israelites?: An Israelite was part of the covenant community through circumcision (compare John 1:47; Romans 9:4). Paul had this mark too and was a Pharisee, a very devoted follower of the Torah (Acts 26:4–5; Romans 11:1; Philippians 3:5–6).
- Are they descendants of Abraham?: This was another claim by Paul's opponents to God's favor based on ethnic identity. Elsewhere, Paul explains who can truly be called Israelites and descendants of Abraham (see Romans 2:28–29; Galatians 3:16, 26–29). Here, he ironically uses his opponents' flawed perspective to outdo them.

2 Corinthians 11:23–24

- in more imprisonments: Paul was imprisoned many times. For example, see Acts 16:22–23. Clement of Rome states that Paul was imprisoned seven times.
- the forty lashes minus one: This punishment is described in Deuteronomy 25:1–3. The Jewish leaders punished Paul as a renegade Jew, and he repeatedly faced death.

2 Corinthians 11:23–27

I am so much more!: Paul's service to Christ involved suffering and hard work like Christ's. Some of these challenges are recorded in Acts.

2 Corinthians 11:25

- Paul was beaten with rods three times. This Roman punishment happened at Philippi, even though he was a Roman citizen and should have been exempt (Acts 16:22–24, 37).
- He was stoned once at Lystra (Acts 14:19).
- He was shipwrecked three times. These events are not detailed elsewhere. Paul's shipwreck on the way to Rome happened later (Acts 27:1–44).

2 Corinthians 11:26–27

Paul's long journeys are recorded in Acts 13–28. He faced danger and endured hardship on these trips.

2 Corinthians 11:28

Besides physical challenges, Paul felt the weight of concern (or anxiety) for all the churches. Corinth caused Paul the most concern.

2 Corinthians 11:30

The things that show my weakness: Paul explores this theme in 12:1–10.

2 Corinthians 11:32–33

- As a final "boast" of his weakness, Paul shares the story of his escape from Damascus a few years after his conversion (see Acts 9:23–25; Galatians 1:15–18).
- King Aretas IV of Nabataea controlled Damascus only after AD 37, following the death of Emperor Tiberius (see Josephus, Antiquities 18.5.1–3). The mention of Aretas dates Paul's escape from Damascus between AD 37 and the end of Aretas's reign in AD 39 or 40.

2 Corinthians 12:1

Although there is nothing to gain: See study note on 2 Corinthians 11:21b–29.

2 Corinthians 12:1–7

Paul's accusers in Corinth claimed he lacked ecstatic spiritual experiences. They said he was not a mystic, just an ordinary person without impressive gifts (see 10:10). Although Paul's authority did not rely on visions and revelations from the Lord, he disclosed that he did have such experiences.

2 Corinthians 12:2

- I know a man in Christ who was caught up: In Greek, Paul modestly uses the third person to refer to himself.
- The third heaven is a Jewish term for being in God's immediate presence.
- Fourteen years ago means around AD 43.

2 Corinthians 12:3–4

- Paul was unsure if he was in a trance or truly taken to heaven.
- And I know this man ... was caught up to Paradise: Literally But I know such a man, that he was caught up; see study note on 12:2.

2 Corinthians 12:5–7

Paul could talk about his experience (12:2–4), but it did not give him confidence in his ministry. He never uses mystical experiences to prove his apostolic authority. His life and message must be the proof. Instead, he talks about his weaknesses (11:23–33).

2 Corinthians 12:7–10

- We do not know what Paul's thorn in the flesh was (see Numbers 33:55; Ezekiel 28:24; Hosea 2:6). We only know it was meant to keep him humble, to burst his pride.
- It was a messenger from Satan, meaning something or someone evil, so Paul asked the Lord to remove it. The Lord replied each time, "My grace is all you need. My power works best in weakness." Paul's weakness allowed Christ's power to work through him by God's grace. Paul accepted his suffering because Christ's strength showed through his weakness.

2 Corinthians 12:11

"super apostles": See 11:5.

2 Corinthians 12:11–13

Paul reviews his credentials as an apostle. He acts like a fool, making proud boasts because his critics have forced him to do so (see study note on 2 Corinthians 11:16–29). Paul also has a commission as an apostle, sent by God himself, with all the signs to prove it.

2 Corinthians 12:12

Paul's credentials included his patience in dealing with difficult people like the Corinthians.

2 Corinthians 12:13

- except that I was not a burden to you: The only thing Paul failed to do was accept payment for his services (see 11:7–11).
- Forgive me this wrong!: This request is ironic and humorous.

2 Corinthians 12:14–15

- a third time: Paul's first visit was when he first preached in Corinth (Acts 18:1–18). The second was an unexpected "painful visit" (2 Corinthians 2:1). Paul hopes the next visit will be happier, but there is still some distrust. They need to clear the air.
- I will not be a burden: Paul did not want their money. He wanted them to fully accept his authority. He was willing to give his time and energy for them instead of taking payment.

2 Corinthians 12:16–18

Some Corinthians still believed Paul had tricked them. They might have suggested Paul took money from the collection for the Jerusalem church (chapters 8–9). The response to this accusation is a reminder of the honesty of Titus and the other brother (see 8:18–

24). The integrity of Paul and his associates should disprove these false claims.

2 Corinthians 12:19

Paul is not just defending his actions and motives. He wants to assure his dear friends of his true love and Christian service for the church's well-being.

2 Corinthians 12:20–21

- Paul worried about facing rebellion and resistance during his upcoming visit. He feared the Corinthians had returned to their old ways.
- you may not find me as you wish: If necessary, Paul would respond firmly to obvious sinners (compare 1:23–2:17; 1 Corinthians 4:21).

2 Corinthians 12:21

- Paul fears that God will humble him in their presence, similar to the previous visit (2:1), when the Corinthians had rejected and humiliated him.
- The listed vices were among the Corinthians' old sins (see 6:14–7:1; 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, "Setting").

2 Corinthians 13:1–2

Paul announced his plan to return to Corinth for the third time (see study note on 12:14–15). He found support for his plan in the Scriptures. The reason for this quote is unclear. However, considering the context of Deuteronomy 19:15, Paul might have wanted to warn them. He intended to judge every wrongdoing (listed in 2 Corinthians 12:20–21) upon his arrival. The two or three witnesses against the Corinthian wrongdoers were Paul's letters or visits and his promise to come the third time.

2 Corinthians 13:3–4

- Christ is speaking through me: Paul represented Christ to the Corinthian congregation and used God's power to guide them.
- Paul's weakness mirrored Christ's humiliation, as Christ was crucified in weakness (see 8:9). Paul judged sinners with Christ's love in mind (5:14–21).
- We are also weak: Paul's humanity was frail, but he relied on Christ's strength (12:10).

2 Corinthians 13:5–6

The issue is straightforward. If the Corinthians cannot see that Jesus Christ is living among them, they have failed the test of true faith (literally are disproved). There is a wordplay here: They wanted "proof" of Paul's authority as an apostle, but Paul tells them to test themselves (or prove yourselves). If Christ is not present, it would show they are not true Christians. However, Paul has shown that he has passed the test of apostolic authority (literally not been disproved).

2 Corinthians 13:7

- that you will not do anything wrong: They would do wrong by following the false teachers who had appeared (11:5, 13–15; see study note on 10:1–13:13).
- even if we appear to have failed: Paul's goal in ministry is to be faithful, not to seem successful (1 Corinthians 4:2). He modeled his service on Jesus Christ himself (2 Corinthians 13:4), who seemed weak and a failure by dying on the cross. But Jesus is now victorious as he lives by God's mighty power.

2 Corinthians 13:7–10

Despite the problems Paul faced at Corinth, his main goal was clear. He wanted the best for these people, hoping they would become mature and strong. Paul always aimed to improve their well-being, even when he corrected them.

2 Corinthians 13:9

for your perfection: This Greek word sometimes means repair or completion. It refers to restoring something to its proper condition, like returning to good health. A related word appears in 2 Corinthians 13:11 as "perfect harmony"; Mark 1:19 as "mending"; 1 Thessalonians 3:10 as "complete"; Hebrews 13:21 as "equip"; and 1 Peter 5:10 as "restore."

2 Corinthians 13:10

- Paul did not want to punish the Corinthians harshly (12:21). He aimed to use his apostolic authority positively. However, his role required him to both strengthen and tear down (compare Jeremiah 1:10).
- for building you up: This is Paul's favorite way to describe a stable Christian community (see Ephesians 4:12), where the Lord lives in and among the believers (2 Corinthians 13:5).

2 Corinthians 13:11

- These last words are Paul's final instructions.
- rejoice!: See also Philippians 3:1; 4:4.
- Aim for perfect harmony: See study note on 2 Corinthians 13:9. Paul encourages them to aim for restoration.
- encourage one another: The need for encouragement is very important in 2 Corinthians, starting with 1:3–7.

- be of one mind: Paul encourages them to live in harmony (as in Philippians 2:1–4).

2 Corinthians 13:11–14

The letter ends with:

- Paul's final request (13:11),
- greetings (13:12–13), and
- a blessing (13:14).

2 Corinthians 13:12–13

- holy kiss: The kiss was a common Jewish greeting, not just a sign of personal affection. It was common in the New Testament church (Romans 16:16; 1 Corinthians 16:20; 1 Thessalonians 5:26; 1 Peter 5:14). It may have held significance in worship services by uniting fellow believers (the "kiss of peace"). The word for sacred (Greek hagiō) is the same word translated as God's people (literally the saints; Greek hagioi) in the next sentence.
- God's people here were the believers in the place where Paul was writing in Macedonia.

2 Corinthians 13:14

- Paul ends his letter with a prayer and blessing. He mentions the three persons of the Trinity, starting with the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ (see 8:9). This is because we always rely on Christ's sacrificial love, which reconciles us to God the Father (5:18–21) and unites us through the fellowship of the Holy Spirit with all believers.
- The love of God meets our needs and graciously brings us back to his family.
- The fellowship of the Holy Spirit refers to our connection with the Spirit, who unites Christians (Ephesians 4:3; Philippians 2:1).